

Ion

ION

Plato

translated by David Horan

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S: Greetings Ion, from where are you visiting us today? From your home in Ephesus¹?

ΣΩ. τὸν Ἴωνα χαίρειν. πόθεν τὰ νῦν ἡμῖν ἐπιδεδήμηκας; ἢ οἴκοθεν ἐξ Ἐφέσου; ΙΩΝ. οὐδαμῶς, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἀλλ' ἐξ Ἐπιδαύρου ἐκ τῶν Ἀσκληπιείων. ΣΩ. μὲν καὶ ῥαψωδῶν ἀγῶνα τιθέασιν τῷ θεῷ οἱ Ἐπιδαύριοι; ΙΩΝ. πάννυ γε, καὶ τῆς ἄλλης γε μουσικῆς. ΣΩ. τί οὖν; ἡγωνίζου τι ἡμῖν; καὶ πῶς τι ἡγωνίσω;

IO: Not at all, Socrates. No, I have come from the festival of Asclepius at Epidaurus.

S: Oh, have the Epidaurians also instituted a contest for rhapsodes in honour of the god?

IO: They have indeed, and for music and poetry in general.

S: Well then, did you compete for us? How did you get on?

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IO: We came away with first prize, Socrates.

ΙΩΝ. τὰ πρῶτα τῶν ἄθλων ἡνεγκάμεθα, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. εὖ λέγεις· ἄγε δὴ ὅπως καὶ τὰ Παναθήναια νικήσομεν. ΙΩΝ. ἀλλ' ἔσται ταῦτα, ἐὰν θεὸς ἐθέλῃ. ΣΩ. καὶ μὴν πολλάκις γε ἐζήλωσα ὑμᾶς τοὺς ῥαψωδοὺς, ὦ Ἴων, τῆς τέχνης· τὸ γὰρ ἅμα μὲν τὸ σῶμα κεκοσμηθῆναι ἀεὶ πρέπον ὑμῶν εἶναι τῇ τέχνῃ καὶ ὡς καλλίστοις φαίνεσθαι, ἅμα δὲ ἀναγκαῖον εἶναι ἔν τε ἄλλοις ποιηταῖς διατρίβειν πολλοῖς καὶ ἀγαθοῖς καὶ δὴ καὶ μάλιστα ἐν Ὀμήρῳ, τῷ ἀρίστῳ καὶ θειοτάτῳ τῶν ποιητῶν, καὶ τὴν τούτου διάνοιαν

S: That is good to hear. Make sure that we win at the Panathenaea too.

IO: That will happen, God willing.

S: And indeed, Ion, I have often been envious of the skill of you rhapsodes. For it is always appropriate to this profession of yours that you are dressed up and look as beautiful as you possibly can. And again, we envy the fact that you need to occupy your time with various poets,

lots of them, good ones too, and especially with Homer, the best and most divine of them all, and thoroughly understand his thought and not his words alone. For no one could ever be a good rhapsode unless he understood the sayings of the poet. Indeed, the rhapsode must act for the audience as an interpreter of the thought of the poet, and it is impossible to do this properly without knowing what the poet means. And all this is enviable.

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IO: That's true, Socrates. Yes, for me this constitutes the main function of my skill. Indeed, I believe that I discourse on Homer more beautifully than anyone else. And I think neither Metrodorus of Lampsacus, nor Stesimbrotos of Thasos, nor Glaucon, nor anyone else that was ever born has had so many beautiful reflections to offer on Homer as I have.

ἐκμανθάνειν, μὴ μόνον τὰ ἔπη, ζηλωτόν ἐστιν. οὐ γὰρ ἂν γένοιτό ποτε ἀγαθὸς ῥαψωδός, εἰ μὴ συνείη τὰ λεγόμενα ὑπὸ τοῦ ποιητοῦ. τὸν γὰρ ῥαψωδὸν ἐρμηνέα δεῖ τοῦ ποιητοῦ τῆς διανοίας γίνεσθαι τοῖς ἀκούουσι· τοῦτο δὲ καλῶς ποιεῖν μὴ γινώσκοντα ὅτι λέγει ὁ ποιητὴς ἀδύνατον. ταῦτα οὖν πάντα ἄξια ζηλοῦσθαι. **ION.** ἀληθῆ λέγεις, ὦ Σώκρατες· ἐμοὶ γοῦν τοῦτο πλεῖστον ἔργον παρέσχεν τῆς τέχνης, καὶ οἶμαι κάλλιστα ἀνθρώπων λέγειν περὶ Ὅμηρου, ὡς οὔτε Μητροδόωρος ὁ

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S: Well said, Ion. Yes, you obviously won't begrudge me a demonstration.

Λαμψακηνὸς οὔτε Στησίμβροτος ὁ Θάσιος οὔτε Γλαύκων οὔτε ἄλλος οὐδεὶς τῶν πώποτε γενομένων ἔσχεν εἰπεῖν οὕτω πολλὰς καὶ καλὰς διανοίας περὶ Ὅμηρου ὅσας ἐγώ. **ΣΩ.** εὖ λέγεις, ὦ Ἴων· δῆλον γὰρ ὅτι οὐ φθονήσεις μοι ἐπιδείξαι. **ION.** καὶ μὴν ἄξιόν γε ἀκοῦσαι, ὦ Σώκρατες, ὡς εὖ κεκόσμηκα τὸν Ὅμηρον· ὥστε οἶμαι ὑπὸ Ὀμηριδῶν ἄξιος εἶναι χρυσῷ στεφάνῳ στεφανωθῆναι. **ΣΩ.** καὶ μὴν ἐγὼ ἔτι ποιήσομαι σχολὴν ἀκροάσασθαι

IO: Yes indeed, Socrates, it is well worth hearing how nicely I have embellished Homer. I believe I deserve to be crowned with a wreath of

gold by the Homerids.

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S: And I shall indeed make time to listen to you some time, but for now please answer this question for me. Are you an expert only on Homer, or on Hesiod and Archilochus too?

σου, νῦν δέ μοι τοσόνδε ἀποκρίναι· πότερον περὶ Ὀμήρου μόνον δεινὸς εἶ ἢ καὶ περὶ Ἡσιόδου καὶ Ἀρχιλόχου; **ΙΩΝ.** οὐδαμῶς, ἀλλὰ περὶ Ὀμήρου μόνον· ἱκανὸν γάρ μοι δοκεῖ εἶναι. **ΣΩ.** ἔστι δὲ περὶ οὗτου Ὀμηρὸς τε καὶ Ἡσιόδου ταῦτά λέγετον; **ΙΩΝ.** οἶμαι ἔγωγε καὶ πολλά. **ΣΩ.** πότερον οὖν περὶ τούτων κάλλιον ἂν ἐξηγήσαιο ἢ Ὀμηρος λέγει ἢ ἢ Ἡσιόδου; **ΙΩΝ.** ὁμοίως ἂν περὶ γε τούτων, ὦ

ΙΟ: Not at all, Socrates, only on Homer. I think that is enough.

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S: And is there anything about which both Homer and Hesiod say the same things?

Σώκρατες, περὶ ὧν ταῦτά λέγουσιν. **ΣΩ.** τί δὲ ὧν πέρι μὴ ταῦτά λέγουσιν; οἷον περὶ μαντικῆς λέγει τι Ὀμηρὸς τε καὶ Ἡσιόδου. **ΙΩΝ.** πάννυ γε. **ΣΩ.** τί οὖν; ὅσα τε ὁμοίως καὶ ὅσα διαφόρως περὶ μαντικῆς λέγετον τῷ ποιητῇ τούτῳ, πότερον σὺ κάλλιον ἂν ἐξηγήσαιο ἢ τῶν μάντεων τις τῶν ἀγαθῶν; **ΙΩΝ.** τῶν μάντεων. **ΣΩ.** εἰ δὲ σὺ ἦσθα μάντις, οὐκ, εἴπερ περὶ τῶν ὁμοίως λεγομένων οἷός τ' ἦσθα ἐξηγήσασθαι, καὶ περὶ τῶν διαφόρως λεγομένων ἠπίστω ἂν ἐξηγεῖσθαι; **ΙΩΝ.** δῆλον ὅτι.

ΙΟ: Yes, I think there are many.

S: Now, would you better interpret what Homer says about such matters than what Hesiod says?

ΙΟ: Well, Socrates, on matters where they say the same things, it would make no difference.

S: What about matters where they do not say the same things? For example, both Homer and Hesiod have something to say about prophecy.

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IO: Certainly.

ΣΩ. τί οὖν ποτε περὶ μὲν Ὅμηρου δεινὸς εἶ, περὶ δὲ Ἡσιόδου οὐ, οὐδὲ τῶν ἄλλων ποιητῶν; ἢ Ὅμηρος περὶ ἄλλων τινῶν λέγει ἢ ὥνπερ σύμπαντες οἱ ἄλλοι ποιηταί; οὐ περὶ πολέμου τε τὰ πολλὰ διελέλυθεν καὶ περὶ ὁμιλιῶν πρὸς ἀλλήλους ἀνθρώπων ἀγαθῶν τε καὶ κακῶν καὶ ἰδιωτῶν καὶ δημιουργῶν, καὶ περὶ θεῶν πρὸς ἀλλήλους καὶ πρὸς ἀνθρώπους ὁμιλούντων, ὡς ὁμιλοῦσι, καὶ περὶ τῶν οὐρανίων παθημάτων καὶ περὶ τῶν ἐν Ἄιδου, καὶ γενέσεις καὶ θεῶν

S: Well then, would you yourself or one of the good prophets better explain the extent to which these two poets agree about prophecy, and the extent to which they differ?

IO: One of the prophets.

S: But if you were a prophet, if you were indeed able to explain what they agree about, wouldn't you know also how to explain what they differ about?

IO: Of course.

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S: So, on what precisely are you an expert in relation to Homer, but not in relation either to Hesiod or the other poets? Or does Homer speak on some matters that are different from what all the other poets speak of? Doesn't Homer give accounts of warfare and the dealings with one another of good people and bad, private citizens and craftsmen, and how the gods deal with one another and with humanity, what happens in heaven and in Hades, and the births of gods and heroes? Are these not the subjects of Homer's poetry?

καὶ ἡρώων; οὐ ταῦτά ἐστι περὶ ὧν Ὅμηρος τὴν ποίησιν πεποίηκεν; ΙΩΝ. ἀληθῆ λέγεις, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. τί δὲ οἱ ἄλλοι ποιηταί; οὐ περὶ τῶν αὐτῶν τούτων; ΙΩΝ. ναί, ἀλλ', ὦ Σώκρατες, οὐχ ὁμοίως πεποιήκασιν καὶ Ὅμηρος. ΣΩ. τί μήν; κάκιον; ΙΩΝ. πολὺ γε. ΣΩ. Ὅμηρος δὲ ἄμεινον; ΙΩΝ.

ἄμεινον μέντοι νῆ Δία. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν, ὦ φίλη κεφαλὴ Ἴων, ὅταν περὶ ἀριθμοῦ πολλῶν λεγόντων εἷς τις ἄριστα λέγῃ, γνώσεται δήπου τις

IO: That's true, Socrates.

S: What about the other poets? Don't they write on the same subjects?

IO: Yes, Socrates, but they don't compose like Homer does.

S: I see. Are they worse?

IO: Much worse.

S: And is Homer better?

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IO: Better indeed, by Zeus.

τὸν εὖ λέγοντα; ΙΩΝ. φημί. ΣΩ. πότερον οὖν ὁ αὐτὸς ὅσπερ καὶ τοὺς κακῶς λέγοντας, ἢ ἄλλος; ΙΩΝ. ὁ αὐτὸς δήπου. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν ὁ τὴν ἀριθμητικὴν τέχνην ἔχων οὗτός ἐστιν; ΙΩΝ. ναί. ΣΩ. τί δ'; ὅταν πολλῶν λεγόντων περὶ ὑγιεινῶν σιτίων ὁποῖα ἐστίν, εἷς τις ἄριστα λέγῃ, πότερον ἕτερος μὲν τις τὸν ἄριστα λέγοντα γνώσεται ὅτι ἄριστα λέγει, ἕτερος δὲ τὸν κάκιον ὅτι κάκιον, ἢ ὁ αὐτός; ΙΩΝ. δῆλον δήπου, ὁ αὐτός. ΣΩ. τίς οὗτος; τί ὄνομα αὐτῷ; ΙΩΝ. ἱατρός. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν ἐν κεφαλαίῳ λέγομεν ὡς ὁ αὐτὸς γνώσεται ἀεὶ, περὶ τῶν αὐτῶν πολλῶν λεγόντων,

S: Well now, dearest Ion, whenever a number of people are speaking about arithmetic and one person speaks better than the others, someone will presumably recognise who the good speaker is?

IO: I agree.

S: Now, will the same person or someone else also recognise the bad speaker?

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IO: The same person, I presume.

ὅστις τε εὖ λέγει καὶ ὅστις κακῶς· ἢ εἰ μὴ γνώσεται τὸν κακῶς λέγοντα, δῆλον ὅτι οὐδὲ τὸν εὖ, περὶ γε τοῦ αὐτοῦ. ΙΩΝ. οὕτως. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν ὁ αὐτὸς γίγνεται δεινὸς περὶ ἀμφοτέρων; ΙΩΝ. ναί. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν σὺ φῆς καὶ

Ὅμηρον καὶ τοὺς ἄλλους ποιητάς, ἐν οἷς καὶ Ἡσίοδος καὶ Ἀρχίλοχος ἐστίν, περὶ γε τῶν αὐτῶν λέγειν, ἀλλ' οὐχ ὁμοίως, ἀλλὰ τὸν μὲν εὖ γε, τοὺς δὲ χειρόν; ἸΩΝ. καὶ ἀληθῆ λέγω. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν, εἴπερ τὸν εὖ λέγοντα γινώσκεις,

S: Wouldn't that person be someone who is skilled in arithmetic?

IO: Yes.

S: What about this? Whenever a number of people are speaking about the kind of foods that are healthy, and one person speaks best, will a different person or the same person recognise that the best speaker speaks best and that the worse speaker speaks worse?

IO: The same person, of course.

S: Who is this person? What is the name for him?

IO: A physician.

S: To sum up, then, we are saying that when a number of people are speaking about the same matters, the same person will always recognise both who is speaking well and who is speaking badly. Or if the person does not recognise who is speaking badly, neither will he, of course, recognise who is speaking well on the same matter.

IO: Quite so.

S: So the same person is an expert in relation to both?

IO: Yes.

S: Now, you maintain, don't you, that Homer and the other poets, including Hesiod and Archilochus, speak about the same things but not in the same way; one speaks well, the others not so well.

IO: Yes, and what I say is true.

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S: Therefore, since you recognise who speaks well, you would also recognise that those who speak less well are speaking worse.

καὶ τοὺς χεῖρον λέγοντας γινώσκοις ἂν ὅτι χεῖρον λέγουσιν. ΙΩΝ. ἔοικέν γε. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν, ὧ βέλτιστε, ὁμοίως τὸν Ἴωνα λέγοντες περὶ Ὅμηρου τε δεινὸν εἶναι καὶ περὶ τῶν ἄλλων ποιητῶν οὐχ ἁμαρτησόμεθα, ἐπειδὴ γε αὐτὸς ὁμολογῇ τὸν αὐτὸν ἔσεσθαι κριτὴν ἱκανὸν πάντων ὅσοι ἂν περὶ τῶν αὐτῶν λέγωσι, τοὺς δὲ ποιητὰς σχεδὸν ἅπαντας τὰ αὐτὰ ποιεῖν. ΙΩΝ. τί οὖν ποτε τὸ αἴτιον, ὧ Σώκρατες, ὅτι ἐγώ, ὅταν μὲν τις περὶ ἄλλου τοῦ ποιητοῦ διαλέγεται, οὔτε προσέχω

IO: Quite likely.

S: In that case, best of men, we shall not be in error if we say that Ion is as much an expert when speaking about Homer as he is when speaking of the other poets, since he himself agrees that the same person will be an adequate judge of all those who speak about the same matters, and all of the poets write, more or less, about the same things.

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IO: Well then, Socrates, can you explain why, when someone discusses some other poet, I pay no attention and am unable to contribute anything of note? I simply doze off. But once someone mentions Homer, I am immediately awake, I pay attention and have plenty to say.

τὸν νοῦν ἀδυνατῶ τε καὶ ὁτιοῦν συμβαλέσθαι λόγου ἄξιον, ἀλλ' ἀτεχνῶς νυστάζω, ἐπειδὴν δέ τις περὶ Ὅμηρου μνησθῇ, εὐθύς τε ἐγρήγορα καὶ προσέχω τὸν νοῦν καὶ εὐπορῶ ὅτι λέγω; ΣΩ. οὐ χαλεπὸν τοῦτό γε εἰκάσαι, ὧ ἑταῖρε, ἀλλὰ παντὶ δῆλον ὅτι τέχνη καὶ ἐπιστήμη περὶ Ὅμηρου λέγειν ἀδύνατος εἶ· εἰ γὰρ τέχνη οἷός τε ἦσθα, καὶ περὶ τῶν ἄλλων ποιητῶν ἀπάντων λέγειν οἷός τ' ἂν ἦσθα· ποιητικὴ γάρ πού ἐστιν τὸ ὅλον. ἦ οὐ; ΙΩΝ. ναί.

S: This is not a difficult question, my friend. No, it is obvious to anyone that you lack the ability to speak skilfully and knowledgeably about Homer. For if you were able to speak skilfully about him you would also be able to speak about all the other poets, since poetry is presumably one whole, is it not?

IO: It is.

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S: Now, once someone grasps any other skill as a whole, will the same manner of enquiry apply to all of the other skills? Do you need me to explain what I mean by this, Ion?

ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν ἐπειδὴν λάβῃ τις καὶ ἄλλην τέχνην ἡντινοῦν ὅλην, ὁ αὐτὸς τρόπος τῆς σκέψεως ἔσται περὶ ἀπασῶν τῶν τεχνῶν; πῶς τοῦτο λέγω, δέῃ τί μου ἀκοῦσαι, ὦ Ἴων; ΙΩΝ. ναὶ μὰ τὸν Δία, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἔγωγε· χαίρω γὰρ ἀκούων ὑμῶν τῶν σοφῶν. ΣΩ. βουλοίμην ἄν σε ἀληθῆ λέγειν, ὦ Ἴων· ἀλλὰ σοφοὶ μὲν πού ἐστε ὑμεῖς οἱ ῥαψωδοὶ καὶ ὑποκρίται καὶ ὧν ὑμεῖς ᾄδετε τὰ ποιήματα, ἐγὼ δὲ οὐδὲν ἄλλο ἢ τάληθῆ λέγω,

IO: I do, by Zeus, Socrates. Indeed, I enjoy listening to you wise men.

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S: I wish you were speaking the truth, Ion. But it is, I believe, you rhapsodes and actors and those whose poems you recite, who are wise, while I do nothing but speak the truth like any common person. Take the question I just asked you. See how ordinary and commonplace it is. Anyone at all could understand my meaning. Is the enquiry the same once someone has understood a skill as a whole? Let's come to an understanding by means of an argument. Is there a skill of painting as a whole?

οἷον εἰκὸς ἰδιώτην ἄνθρωπον. ἐπεὶ καὶ περὶ τούτου οὗ νῦν ἡρόμην σε, θέασαι ὡς φαῦλον καὶ ἰδιωτικόν ἐστι καὶ παντὸς ἀνδρὸς γινῶναι ὃ ἔλεγον, τὴν αὐτὴν εἶναι σκέψιν, ἐπειδὴν τις ὅλην τέχνην λάβῃ. λάβωμεν γὰρ τῷ λόγῳ· γραφικὴ γάρ τίς ἐστι τέχνη τὸ ὅλον; ΙΩΝ. ναί. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν καὶ γραφῆς πολλοὶ καὶ εἰσὶ καὶ γεγόνασιν ἀγαθοὶ καὶ φαῦλοι; ΙΩΝ. πάνυ γε. ΣΩ. ἤδη οὖν τινα εἶδες ὅστις περὶ μὲν Πολυγνώτου τοῦ Ἀγλαοφῶντος δεινός ἐστιν ἀποφαίνειν ἃ εὖ τε γράφει καὶ ἃ μὴ, περὶ δὲ τῶν ἄλλων γραφέων

IO: Yes.

S: And there are, and there have been, many good and not so good painters.

IO: Certainly.

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S: Well, have you ever come across anyone who is an expert in pointing out what Polygnotus, the son of Aglaophon, paints well, and what he does not, while being unable to do so in the case of other painters? Do you know anyone who dozes off, is at a loss, and has nothing to contribute whenever anyone exhibits the works of the other painters, but is wide awake, attentive, with plenty to say when asked to give an opinion on Polygnotus or any other painter you wish, and on that one alone?

ἀδύνατος; καὶ ἐπειδὴν μὲν τις τὰ τῶν ἄλλων ζωγράφων ἔργα ἐπιδεικνύη, νυστάζει τε καὶ ἀπορεῖ καὶ οὐκ ἔχει ὅτι συμβάληται, ἐπειδὴν δὲ περὶ Πολυγνώτου ἢ ἄλλου ὅτου βούλει τῶν γραφέων ἑνὸς μόνου δέη ἀποφήνασθαι γνώμην, ἐργήγορέν τε καὶ προσέχει τὸν νοῦν καὶ εὐπορεῖ ὅτι εἴπη; **ION.** οὐ μὰ τὸν Δία, οὐ δῆτα. **ΣΩ.** τί δέ; ἐν ἀνδριαντοποιίᾳ ἤδη τιν' εἶδες ὅστις περὶ μὲν Δαιδάλου τοῦ Μητίονος

IO: No, by Zeus. Not at all.

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S: What about sculpting? Have you ever come across anyone who is an expert in explaining what's good about the works of Daedalus, son of Metion, or Epeius, son of Panopeius, or Theodorus, son of Zamion, or any other individual sculptor, but is at a loss, dozes off, and has nothing to say, when faced with the works of the other sculptors?

ἢ Ἐπειοῦ τοῦ Πανοπέως ἢ Θεοδώρου τοῦ Σαμίου ἢ ἄλλου τινὸς ἀνδριαντοποιιοῦ ἑνὸς περὶ δεινὸς ἐστὶν ἐξηγεῖσθαι ἃ εὖ πεποίηκεν, ἐν δὲ τοῖς τῶν ἄλλων ἀνδριαντοποιῶν ἔργοις ἀπορεῖ τε καὶ νυστάζει, οὐκ ἔχων ὅτι εἴπη; **ION.** οὐ μὰ τὸν Δία, οὐδὲ τοῦτον ἑώρακα. **ΣΩ.** ἀλλὰ μήν, ὥς γ' ἐγὼ οἶμαι, οὐδ' ἐν αὐλήσει γε οὐδὲ ἐν κιθαρίσει οὐδὲ ἐν κιθαρωδίᾳ οὐδὲ ἐν ῥαψωδίᾳ οὐδεπώποτ' εἶδες ἄνδρα ὅστις περὶ μὲν Ὀλύμπου δεινὸς ἐστὶν ἐξηγεῖσθαι ἢ περὶ Θαμύρου ἢ περὶ

IO: No, by Zeus, I have not come across this either.

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S: Then again, in the case of flute-playing, or playing the cithara whilst singing or not singing, or performing as a rhapsode, I am sure you have never come across someone who is an expert in explaining about Olympus or Thamyras or Orpheus or Phemion, the Ithacan rhapsode, while being at a loss about Ionos of Ephesus, with nothing to contribute in relation to what he performs well or ill.

Ὅρφέως ἢ περὶ Φημίου τοῦ Ἰθακησίου ῥαψωδοῦ, περὶ δὲ Ἴωνος τοῦ Ἐφεσίου ῥαψωδοῦ ἀπορεῖ καὶ οὐκ ἔχει συμβαλέσθαι ἅ τε εὖ ῥαψωδεῖ καὶ ἅ μὴ. **ION.** οὐκ ἔχω σοι περὶ τούτου ἀντιλέγειν, ὦ Σώκρατες· ἀλλ' ἐκεῖνο ἐμαυτῷ σύννοια, ὅτι περὶ Ὀμήρου κάλλιστ' ἀνθρώπων λέγω καὶ εὐπορῶ καὶ οἱ ἄλλοι πάντες μέ φασιν εὖ λέγειν, περὶ δὲ τῶν ἄλλων οὔ. καίτοι ὅρα τοῦτο τί ἔστιν. **ΣΩ.** καὶ ὁρῶ, ὦ Ἴων, καὶ ἔρχομαί γέ σοι ἀποφανόμενος

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IO: I am unable to argue against you on this, Socrates. But I am aware that I speak more beautifully about Homer than anyone else. I have plenty to say, and everyone agrees that I speak well. But I don't speak well about the others. So please, look at what this means.

ὅ μοι δοκεῖ τοῦτο εἶναι. ἔστι γὰρ τοῦτο τέχνη μὲν οὐκ ὄν παρὰ σοὶ περὶ Ὀμήρου εὖ λέγειν, ὃ νυνδὴ ἔλεγον, θεία δὲ δύναμις ἢ σε κινεῖ, ὥσπερ ἐν τῇ λίθῳ ἦν Εὐριπίδης μὲν Μαγνητῖν ὠνόμασεν, οἱ δὲ πολλοὶ Ἡρακλείαν. καὶ γὰρ αὕτη ἡ λίθος οὐ μόνον αὐτοὺς τοὺς δακτυλίους ἄγει τοὺς σιδηροῦς, ἀλλὰ καὶ δύναμιν ἐντίθησι τοῖς δακτυλίοις ὥστ' αὐτὸ δύνασθαι ταῦτόν τοῦτο ποιεῖν ὅπερ ἡ λίθος, ἄλλους ἄγειν δακτυλίους, ὥστ' ἐνίοτε ὀρμαθὸς μακρὸς πάνυ σιδηρίων καὶ δακτυλίων ἐξ ἀλλήλων ἥρτηται· πᾶσι δὲ τούτοις ἐξ ἐκείνης τῆς λίθου ἡ δύναμις ἀνήρτηται. οὕτω δὲ καὶ ἡ Μοῦσα ἐνθέους μὲν ποιεῖ αὐτή, διὰ δὲ τῶν ἐνθέων τούτων ἄλλων ἐνθουσιαζόντων ὀρμαθὸς ἐξαρτᾶται. **ΣΩ.** πάντες γὰρ οἱ τε τῶν ἐπῶν ποιηταὶ οἱ ἀγαθοὶ οὐκ ἐκ τέχνης ἀλλ' ἐνθεοὶ ὄντες καὶ κατεχόμενοι πάντα ταῦτα τὰ καλὰ λέγουσι ποιήματα, καὶ οἱ μελοποιοὶ οἱ ἀγαθοὶ ὡσαύτως, ὥσπερ οἱ κορυβαντιῶντες οὐκ ἔμφρονες ὄντες ὀρχοῦνται, οὕτω καὶ οἱ μελοποιοὶ οὐκ ἔμφρονες ὄντες τὰ καλὰ μέλη

ταῦτα ποιοῦσιν, ἀλλ' ἐπειδὴν ἐμβῶσιν εἰς τὴν ἁρμονίαν καὶ εἰς τὸν ῥυθμόν, βακχεύουσι καὶ κατεχόμενοι, ὥσπερ αἱ βάκχαι ἀρύονται ἐκ τῶν ποταμῶν μέλι καὶ γάλα κατεχόμεναι, ἔμφρονες δὲ οὔσαι οὐ, καὶ τῶν μελοποιῶν ἡ ψυχὴ τοῦτο ἐργάζεται, ὅπερ αὐτοὶ λέγουσι. λέγουσι γὰρ δῆπουθεν πρὸς ἡμᾶς οἱ ποιηταὶ ὅτι ἀπὸ κρηνῶν μελιρρύτων ἐκ Μουσῶν κήπων τινῶν καὶ ναπῶν δρεπόμενοι τὰ μέλη ἡμῖν φέρουσιν ὥσπερ αἱ μέλιτται, καὶ αὐτοὶ οὕτω πετόμενοι· καὶ ἀληθῆ λέγουσι. κοῦφον γὰρ χρῆμα ποιητῆς ἐστὶν καὶ πτηνὸν καὶ ἱερόν, καὶ οὐ πρότερον οἷός τε ποιεῖν πρὶν ἂν ἔνθεός τε γένηται καὶ ἔκφρων καὶ ὁ νοῦς μηκέτι ἐν αὐτῷ ἐνῇ· ἕως δ' ἂν τουτὶ ἔχη τὸ κτῆμα, ἀδύνατος πᾶς ποιεῖν ἄνθρωπός ἐστιν καὶ χρησμοδεῖν. ἄτε οὖν οὐ τέχνη ποιοῦντες καὶ πολλὰ λέγοντες καὶ καλὰ περὶ τῶν πραγμάτων, ὥσπερ σὺ περὶ Ὀμήρου, ἀλλὰ θεῖα μοῖρα, τοῦτο μόνον οἷός τε ἕκαστος ποιεῖν καλῶς ἐφ' ὃ ἡ Μοῦσα αὐτὸν ὥρμησεν, ὁ μὲν διθυράμβους, ὁ δὲ ἐγκώμια, ὁ δὲ ὑπορχήματα, ὁ δ' ἔπη, ὁ δ' ἰάμβους· τὰ δ' ἄλλα φαῦλος αὐτῶν ἕκαστός ἐστιν. οὐ γὰρ τέχνη ταῦτα λέγουσιν ἀλλὰ θεῖα δυνάμει, ἐπεὶ εἰ περὶ ἑνὸς τέχνη καλῶς ἠπίσταντο λέγειν, κἂν περὶ τῶν ἄλλων ἀπάντων· διὰ ταῦτα δὲ ὁ θεὸς ἐξαιρούμενος τούτων τὸν νοῦν τούτοις χρῆται ὑπηρέταις καὶ τοῖς χρησμοδοῖς καὶ τοῖς μάντεσι τοῖς θείοις, ἵνα ἡμεῖς οἱ ἀκούοντες εἰδῶμεν ὅτι οὐχ οὗτοί εἰσιν οἱ ταῦτα λέγοντες οὕτω πολλοῦ ἄξια, οἷς νοῦς μὴ πάρεστιν, ἀλλ' ὁ θεὸς αὐτός ἐστιν ὁ λέγων, διὰ τούτων δὲ φθέγγεται πρὸς ἡμᾶς. μέγιστον δὲ τεκμήριον τῷ λόγῳ Τύννιχος ὁ Χαλκιδεύς, ὃς ἄλλο μὲν οὐδὲν πώποτε ἐποίησε ποίημα ὅτου τις ἂν ἀξιόσκειν μνησθῆναι, τὸν δὲ παῖωνα ὃν πάντες ἄδουσι, σχεδόν τι πάντων μελῶν κάλλιστον, ἀτεχνῶς, ὅπερ αὐτὸς λέγει, εὖρημά τι Μοισᾶν. ἐν τούτῳ γὰρ δὴ μάλιστα μοι δοκεῖ ὁ θεὸς ἐνδείξασθαι ἡμῖν, ἵνα μὴ διστάζωμεν, ὅτι οὐκ ἀνθρώπινά ἐστιν τὰ καλὰ ταῦτα ποιήματα οὐδὲ ἀνθρώπων, ἀλλὰ θεῖα καὶ θεῶν, οἱ δὲ ποιηταὶ οὐδὲν ἄλλ' ἢ ἐρμηνῆς εἰσιν τῶν θεῶν, κατεχόμενοι ἐξ ὅτου ἂν ἕκαστος κατέχηται. ταῦτα ἐνδεικνύμενος ὁ θεὸς ἐξεπίτηδες διὰ τοῦ φαυλοτάτου

S: I am looking, Ion, and I'm going to show you what this means, in my opinion. Indeed, as I just said, your speaking well about Homer is not a skill you possess but a divine power that moves you, like the power in

the stones that Euripides called Magnets and most people call Heracleon. And, indeed, the stone itself not only attracts rings that are made of iron, but also imparts power to the rings themselves so that they in turn are able to do the same thing as the stone, and attract other rings. Sometimes there is a very long chain of iron rings, but these are all suspended by the power derived from that stone. In this way, too, the Muse herself inspires people, and through these inspired people others are also inspired in a connected chain. For all our epic poets, the good ones, deliver all of their beautiful poems, not by skill, but whilst inspired and possessed. The same holds for our good lyric poets. Just as Corybantes are not in their sane mind when they dance, so too do our lyric poets compose their beautiful melodies when they enter into the harmony and rhythm, and are frenzied and possessed like the bacchantes who draw honey and milk from the rivers whilst possessed, but not when they are in their sane mind. The soul of our lyric poets does this too, as they themselves confirm. The poets tell us, I believe, that from springs flowing with honey in some gardens and groves of the Muses, they fly like bees gathering melodies and bringing them to us, just as bees do. And what they say is true. For a poet is something light, winged and sacred, unable to compose until inspired, out of their sane mind, with reason no longer present within. But as long as anyone retains possession of this, it is impossible for such a person to compose anything or to engage in prophecy. Now, since it is not by skill but by a divine portion that they compose and have so many beautiful things to say about various matters, as you do about Homer, each of them can only compose in a beautiful manner whatever the Muse impels them to compose. In one case, this will be dithyrambs, and in another it will be encomia or dance songs or epics or iambics, and each of them will be bad at anything else. For they do not speak any of this because of skill, but because of the divine power, since, if in one case they knew how to speak beautifully by means of skill, they would also know how to do so in all other cases too. That is why the god takes reason away from them, using them as his underlings, like

prophets and divine seers. This is so that we who hear them may know that the speakers, being devoid of reason, are not the ones making such valuable pronouncements. Rather, the god himself is speaking, making pronouncements to us through these people. A great proof of this argument is the example of Tynnichos of Chalcis, who never composed another work that anyone might deem worthy of mention, but he did compose the hymn that everyone sings, perhaps the most beautiful melody of all, which really is, as he says himself, “an invention of the Muses”. Indeed, I believe that in this case in particular, the god is demonstrating to us beyond doubt that these beautiful compositions are not human productions of mere humans, but are divine compositions of gods. The poets then are nothing more than the gods’ interpreters, possessed by one or other of the gods. To point this out to us, the god deliberately sang this most beautiful song through the least of our poets. Do you think this is true, Ion?

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IO: Yes, by Zeus, I do indeed. For your words touch my soul, Socrates, and I believe that it is by a divine portion that the good poets interpret for us these pronouncements from the gods.

ποιητοῦ τὸ κάλλιστον μέλος ἦσεν· ἢ οὐ δοκῶ σοι ἀληθῆ λέγειν, ὦ Ἴων; ΙΩΝ. ναὶ μὰ τὸν Δία, ἔμοιγε· ἅπτει γάρ πῶς μου τοῖς λόγοις τῆς ψυχῆς, ὦ Σώκρατες, καί μοι δοκοῦσι θεῖα μοῖρα ἡμῖν παρὰ τῶν θεῶν ταῦτα οἱ ἀγαθοὶ ποιηταὶ ἐρμηνεύειν. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν ὑμεῖς αὖ οἱ ῥαψῳδοὶ τὰ τῶν ποιητῶν ἐρμηνεύετε; ΙΩΝ. καὶ τοῦτο ἀληθὲς λέγεις. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν ἐρμηνέων ἐρμηνῆς γίγνεσθε; ΙΩΝ. παντάπασί γε.

S: Don’t you rhapsodes, in turn, interpret for us the pronouncements of the poets?

IO: That’s true too.

S: Then you are interpreters of interpreters?

IO: Entirely so.

535b

S: Well, stop there, Ion. Answer the question I'm about to ask you and hide nothing. You do well at reciting epic poems and utterly astonish your audience by singing of Odysseus leaping onto the threshold, revealing himself to the suitors and pouring forth the arrows at his feet, or of Achilles lunging at Hector, or when reciting something piteous about Hecuba or Priam. Now, when you do this, are you in your sane mind or are you outside of yourself? Does your inspired soul believe that you are in the midst of the events you are describing in Ithaca or Troy, or wherever the epics are based?

ΣΩ. ἔχε δὴ μοι τόδε εἶπέ, ὦ Ἴων, καὶ μὴ ἀποκρύψῃ ὅτι ἂν σε ἔρωμαι ὅταν εὖ εἴπῃς ἔπη καὶ ἐκπλήξῃς μάλιστα τοὺς θεωμένους, ἢ τὸν Ὀδυσσεά ὅταν ἐπὶ τὸν οὐδὸν ἐφαλλόμενον ἄδῃς, ἐκφανῇ γιγνόμενον τοῖς μνηστῆρσι καὶ ἐκχέοντα τοὺς οἰστοὺς πρὸ τῶν ποδῶν, ἢ Ἀχιλλέα ἐπὶ τὸν Ἑκτορα ὀρμῶντα, ἢ καὶ τῶν περὶ Ἀνδρομάχην ἐλαινῶν τι ἢ περὶ Ἑκάβην ἢ περὶ Πρίαμον, τότε πότερον ἔμφρων εἶ ἢ ἔξω

535c

IO: The example you are giving is quite clear, Socrates. I'll hide nothing from you. Indeed, when I recount something piteous, my eyes fill with tears, and when the story is frightening or awful, the hairs of my head stand on end from fear and my heart pounds.

σαυτοῦ γίγνη καὶ παρὰ τοῖς πράγμασιν οἶται σου εἶναι ἡ ψυχὴ οἷς λέγεις ἐνθουσιάζουσα, ἢ ἐν Ἰθάκῃ οὔσιν ἢ ἐν Τροίᾳ ἢ ὅπως ἂν καὶ τὰ ἔπη ἔχη; ΙΩΝ. ὡς ἐναργές μοι τοῦτο, ὦ Σώκρατες, τὸ τεκμήριον εἶπες· οὐ γάρ σε ἀποκρυψάμενος ἔρῳ. ἐγὼ γὰρ ὅταν ἐλαινόν τι λέγω, δακρύων ἐμπίμπλανταί μου οἱ ὀφθαλμοί· ὅταν τε φοβερὸν ἢ δεινόν, ὀρθαὶ αἱ τρίχες ἴστανται ὑπὸ φόβου καὶ ἡ καρδίᾳ πηδᾷ.

535d

S: Well then, Ion, are we to say that a person is sane of mind who, adorned in finery and wearing a wreath of gold, laments at sacrifices and festivals although none of his adornments are under threat? Is a person sane of mind who is fearful in front of more than 20,000

friendly people, even though none of them are robbing him or doing him wrong?

ΣΩ. τί οὖν; φῶμεν, ὦ Ἴων, ἔμφρονα εἶναι τότε τοῦτον τὸν ἄνθρωπον, ὃς ἂν κεκοσμημένος ἐσθῇτι ποικίλῃ καὶ χρυσοῖσι στεφάνοις κλάῃ τ' ἐν θυσαίαις καὶ ἑορταῖς, μηδὲν ἀπολωλεκῶς τούτων, ἢ φοβῆται πλεόν ἢ ἐν δισμυρίοις ἀνθρώποις ἐστηκῶς φιλίοις, μηδενὸς ἀποδύοντος μηδὲ ἀδικοῦντος; ΙΩΝ. οὐ μὰ τὸν Δία, οὐ πάνυ, ὦ Σώκρατες, ὥς γε τάληθές εἰρήσθαι. ΣΩ. οἶσθα οὖν ὅτι καὶ τῶν θεατῶν τοὺς πολλοὺς ταῦτά ταῦτα ὑμεῖς ἐργάζεσθε;

IO: No, by Zeus, Socrates, not really, to tell you the truth.

S: Now, are you aware that you rhapsodes also affect most of your audience in these same ways?

535e

IO: I know only too well. Yes, every time I look down upon them from the stage they are weeping, looking at me in awe, sharing the astonishment of the tales. In fact, I need to pay close attention to them because if I set them weeping, I'll be laughing for the money I make, but if I set them laughing, I'll be weeping for the money I've lost.

ΙΩΝ. καὶ μάλα καλῶς οἶδα· καθορῶ γὰρ ἐκάστοτε αὐτοὺς ἄνωθεν ἀπὸ τοῦ βήματος κλάοντάς τε καὶ δεινὸν ἐμβλέποντας καὶ συνθαμβοῦντας τοῖς λεγομένοις. δεῖ γάρ με καὶ σφόδρ' αὐτοῖς τὸν νοῦν προσέχειν· ὥς ἐὰν μὲν κλάοντας αὐτοὺς καθίσω, αὐτὸς γελάσομαι ἀργύριον λαμβάνων, ἐὰν δὲ γελῶντας, αὐτὸς κλαύσομαι ἀργύριον ἀπολλύς. ΣΩ. οἶσθα οὖν ὅτι οὗτός ἐστιν ὁ θεατῆς τῶν δακτυλίων ὁ ἔσχατος, ὧν ἐγὼ ἔλεγον ὑπὸ τῆς Ἡρακλειώτιδος λίθου ἀπ' ἀλλήλων τὴν δύναμιν λαμβάνειν; ὁ δὲ μέσος σὺ ὁ

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S: Now, do you know that the spectator is the last of the rings I spoke of which receive from one another the power that comes from the Heracleian stone? The intermediate ring is yourself, the rhapsode, or actor, and the first ring is the actual poet. But the god, making all of these people dependent on one another for their power, through them,

draws the soul of us humans to wherever he wishes. And a vast chain of dancers, teachers and tutors hangs from the side of the rings suspended from the Muse, just as they do from that original stone. One poet hangs upon one Muse, another poet upon another Muse, and we use the phrase “he is possessed”, and this is well-nigh the case because he is ‘held’. And from these initial rings (the poets), others in turn are hanging and are inspired from another, some from Orpheus and others from Musaeus, but most are held and inspired by Homer. You, Ion, are one of those. You are possessed by Homer, and once any other poet is recited you fall asleep and have nothing to say. But once some strain of this poet is uttered you are immediately awake, your soul dances, and you have plenty to say. This is because you don’t say what you say about Homer due to skill or knowledge, but due to possession and a divine portion. You are just like the Corybantes who are keenly aware only of the particular melody of the god who possesses them, and are well equipped with gestures and phrases for that melody, but pay no heed to the others. And, Ion, you asked me to explain why you have so much to say about Homer but not about the others. Well, this is because you are an expert advocate of Homer due to a divine portion rather than skill.

ῥαψωδὸς καὶ ὑποκριτής, ὁ δὲ πρῶτος αὐτὸς ὁ ποιητής· ὁ δὲ θεὸς διὰ πάντων τούτων ἔλκει τὴν ψυχὴν ὅποι ἂν βούληται τῶν ἀνθρώπων, ἀνακρεμαννὺς ἐξ ἀλλήλων τὴν δύναμιν. καὶ ὥσπερ ἐκ τῆς λίθου ἐκείνης ὀρμαθὸς ἀάπολυσ ἐξήρηται χορευτῶν τε καὶ διδασκάλων καὶ ὑποδιδασκάλων, ἐκ πλαγίου ἐξηρημένων τῶν τῆς Μούσης ἐκκρεμαμένων δακτυλίων. καὶ ὁ μὲν τῶν ποιητῶν ἐξ ἄλλης Μούσης, ὁ δὲ ἐξ ἄλλης ἐξήρηται—ὀνομάζομεν δὲ αὐτὸ κατέχεται, τὸ δέ ἐστι παραπλήσιον· ἔχεται γάρ—ἐκ δὲ τούτων τῶν πρώτων δακτυλίων, τῶν ποιητῶν, ἄλλοι ἐξ ἄλλου αὖ ἡρητημένοι εἰσὶ καὶ ἐνθουσιάζουσιν, οἱ μὲν ἐξ Ὀρφέως, οἱ δὲ ἐκ Μουσαίου· οἱ δὲ πολλοὶ ἐξ Ὀμήρου κατέχονται τε καὶ ἔχονται. ὦν σύ, ὦ Ἴων, εἷς εἶ καὶ κατέχη ἐξ Ὀμήρου, καὶ ἐπειδὴν μὲν τις ἄλλου τοῦ ποιητοῦ ἄδη, καθεύδεις τε καὶ ἀπορεῖς ὅτι λέγῃς, ἐπειδὴν δὲ τούτου τοῦ ποιητοῦ φθέγγεται τις μέλος, εὐθὺς ἐγρήγορας

καὶ ὀρχεῖται σου ἢ ψυχὴ καὶ εὐπορεῖς ὅτι λέγῃς· οὐ γὰρ τέχνη οὐδ' ἐπιστήμη περὶ Ὅμηρου λέγεις ἢ λέγεις, ἀλλὰ θεία μοῖρα καὶ κατοκωχῇ, ὥσπερ οἱ κορυβαντιῶντες ἐκείνου μόνου αἰσθάνονται τοῦ μέλους ὁξέως ὃ ἂν ᾗ τοῦ θεοῦ ἐξ ὅτου ἂν κατέχωνται, καὶ εἰς ἐκεῖνο τὸ μέρος καὶ σχημάτων καὶ ῥημάτων εὐποροῦσι, τῶν δὲ ἄλλων οὐ φροντίζουσιν· οὕτω καὶ σύ, ὦ Ἴων, περὶ μὲν Ὅμηρου ὅταν τις μνησθῇ, εὐπορεῖς, περὶ δὲ τῶν ἄλλων ἀπορεῖς·

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IO: Well said, Socrates. However, I would be surprised if you were to speak well enough to convince me that when I praise Homer, I do so whilst possessed or insane. And I don't think you would hold this view of me if you were to hear me speaking about Homer.

τούτου δ' ἐστὶ τὸ αἴτιον, ὃ μ' ἐρωτᾷς, δι' ὅτι σὺ περὶ μὲν Ὅμηρου εὐπορεῖς, περὶ δὲ τῶν ἄλλων οὐ, ὅτι οὐ τέχνη ἀλλὰ θεία μοῖρα Ὅμηρου δεινὸς εἶ ἐπαινέτης. **ION.** σὺ μὲν εὖ λέγεις, ὦ Σώκρατες· θαυμάζοιμι μεντὰν εἰ οὕτως εὖ εἴποις, ὥστε με ἀναπεῖσαι ὡς ἐγὼ κατεχόμενος καὶ μαινόμενος Ὅμηρον ἐπαινῶ. οἶμαι δὲ οὐδ' ἂν σοὶ δόξαιμι, εἴ μου ἀκούσαις λέγοντος περὶ Ὅμηρου. **ΣΩ.** καὶ μὴν ἐθέλω γε ἀκοῦσαι, οὐ μέντοι πρότερον

536e

S: And I do want to hear you, but not before you answer the following question for me. Which of the topics dealt with by Homer are you good at speaking about? Surely not about all of them?

πρὶν ἂν μοι ἀποκρίνη τόδε· ὦν Ὅμηρος λέγει περὶ τίνος εὖ λέγεις; οὐ γὰρ δήπου περὶ ἀπάντων γε. **ION.** εὖ ἴσθι, ὦ Σώκρατες, περὶ οὐδενὸς ὅτου οὐ. **ΣΩ.** οὐ δήπου καὶ περὶ τούτων ὦν σὺ μὲν τυγχάνεις οὐκ εἰδώς, Ὅμηρος δὲ λέγει. **ION.** καὶ ταῦτα ποῖά ἐστιν ἃ Ὅμηρος μὲν λέγει, ἐγὼ δὲ οὐκ οἶδα;

IO: Mark my words, Socrates, there are no exceptions.

S: Surely this is not true of the topics referred to by Homer, of which you have no knowledge?

IO: What sort of topics does Homer speak of which I know nothing about?

S: Doesn't Homer, in various places, make many references to skills? For example, about chariot driving. If I can recall the lines, I'll recite them for you.

IO: No, I'll recite them. I certainly remember them.

S: Then tell me what Nestor says to his son, Antilochus, when advising him to be careful about the turning post during the chariot race in honour of Patroclus.

537a

IO: "...and yourself, in the well-polished chariot, lean over / a little to the left of the course, and as for your right horse, whip him / and urge him along, slackening your hands to give him his full rein, / but make your left-hand horse keep hard against the turning-post / so that the hub's edge of your fashioned wheel will seem to be / touching it, yet take care not really to brush against it..."

ΣΩ. οὐ καὶ περὶ τεχνῶν μέντοι λέγει πολλαχοῦ Ὅμηρος καὶ πολλά; οἶον καὶ περὶ ἥνιοχείας—ἐὰν μνησθῶ τὰ ἔπη, ἐγὼ σοι φράσω. ΙΩΝ. ἀλλ' ἐγὼ ἔρω· ἐγὼ γὰρ μέμνημαι. ΣΩ. εἰπὲ δὴ μοι ἃ λέγει Νέστωρ Ἀντιλόχῳ τῷ ὑεῖ, παραινῶν εὐλαβηθῆναι περὶ τὴν καμπὴν ἐν τῇ ἵπποδρομίᾳ τῇ ἐπὶ Πατρόκλῳ. ΙΩΝ. κλινθῆναι δέ, φησί, καὶ αὐτὸς ἐυξέστω ἐνὶ δίφρῳ

S: That's enough. Now, Ion, who would better understand whether or not, in these lines, Homer is speaking correctly? A physician or a charioteer?

IO: A charioteer, of course.

S: Is this because he possesses that particular skill, or for some other reason?

IO: No, it's because he has the skill.

537b

S: So, has each of the skills been endowed by the god with the ability to understand some activity? For, presumably, whatever we understand through the skill of steering could not also be understood by medical skill.

ἤκ' ἐπ' ἀριστερὰ τοῖν· ἀτὰρ τὸν δεξιὸν ἵππον κένσαι ὁμοκλήσας, εἰξαί τέ οἱ ἡνία χερσίν. ἐν νύσσει δέ τοι ἵππος ἀριστερὸς ἐγχιριμφθήτω, ὥς ἂν τοι πλήμνη γε δοάσσεται ἄκρον ἰκέσθαι κύκλου ποιητοῖο· λίθου δ' ἀλέασθαι ἐπαυρεῖν. ΣΩ. ἀρκεῖ. ταῦτα δῆ, ὦ Ἴων, τὰ ἔπη εἶτε

IO: Of course not.

S: Nor could whatever is understood through medical skill also be understood through the skill of carpentry.

IO: Of course not.

537c

S: Isn't it the case with all skills that whatever we understand by one skill, we could not understand by another? But answer me this first. Do you agree that one skill is different from another?

ὀρθῶς λέγει Ὅμηρος εἶτε μὴ, πότερος ἂν γνοίῃ ἄμεινον, ἱατρὸς ἢ ἡνίοχος; ΙΩΝ. Ἡνίοχος δήπου. ΣΩ. πότερον ὅτι τέχνην ταύτην ἔχει ἢ κατ' ἄλλο τι; ΙΩΝ. οὐκ, ἀλλ' ὅτι τέχνην. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν ἐκάστη τῶν τεχνῶν ἀποδέδοται τι ὑπὸ τοῦ θεοῦ ἔργον οἷα τε εἶναι γινώσκειν; οὐ γάρ που ἃ κυβερνητικῇ γινώσκομεν, γνωσόμεθα καὶ ἱατρικῇ. ΙΩΝ. οὐ δῆτα. ΣΩ. οὐδέ γε ἃ ἱατρικῇ, ταῦτα καὶ τεκτονικῇ. ΙΩΝ.

IO: Yes.

S: Do you argue, as I do, that whenever there is a knowledge of various things and a knowledge of various other things, I call one knowledge a skill, and the other knowledge a different skill. Is this what you do too?

IO: Yes.

537d

S: Indeed, if knowledge were somehow a knowledge of the same things, why would we maintain that one knowledge is different from another,

when the same things could be known by both? For instance, I understand that these fingers are five in number, and you understand the same thing about them as I do. And if I were to ask you if we both know the same things by the same skill, namely arithmetic, or by a different skill, you would of course maintain that it is by the same skill.

οὐ δῆτα. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν οὕτω καὶ κατὰ πασῶν τῶν τεχνῶν, ἃ τῇ ἐτέρᾳ τέχνῃ γινώσκουμεν, οὐ γνωσόμεθα τῇ ἐτέρᾳ; τόδε δέ μοι πρότερον τούτου ἀποκρίναι· τὴν μὲν ἐτέραν φῆς εἶναι τινα τέχνην, τὴν δ' ἐτέραν; ΙΩΝ. ναί. ΣΩ. ἄρα ὥσπερ ἐγὼ τεκμαιρόμενος, ὅταν ἡ μὲν ἐτέρων πραγμάτων ᾗ ἐπιστήμη, ἡ δ' ἐτέρων, οὕτω καλῶ τὴν μὲν ἄλλην, τὴν δὲ ἄλλην

IO: Yes.

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S: Well, you may now answer the question I was about to ask you earlier. Do you think this is so for all skills? Are the same things necessarily understood by the same skill, while whatever is not the same is understood by a different skill? But if the skill is different, must it not also understand different things?

τέχνην, οὕτω καὶ σύ; ΙΩΝ. ναί. ΣΩ. εἰ γάρ που τῶν αὐτῶν πραγμάτων ἐπιστήμη εἴη τις, τί ἂν τὴν μὲν ἐτέραν φαίμεν εἶναι, τὴν δ' ἐτέραν, ὅποτε γε ταῦτα εἴη εἰδέναι ἀπ' ἀμφοτέρων; ὥσπερ ἐγὼ τε γινώσκω ὅτι πέντε εἰσὶν οὗτοι οἱ δάκτυλοι, καὶ σύ, ὥσπερ ἐγὼ, περὶ τούτων ταῦτα γινώσκεις; καὶ εἴ σε ἐγὼ ἐροίμην εἰ τῇ αὐτῇ τέχνῃ γινώσκουμεν τῇ ἀριθμητικῇ τὰ αὐτὰ ἐγὼ τε καὶ σὺ ἢ ἄλλῃ, φαίης ἂν δήπου τῇ αὐτῇ. ΙΩΝ. ναί. ΣΩ. ὃ τοίνυν ἄρτι ἔμελλον ἐρήσεσθαί σε, νυνὶ εἶπέ, εἰ κατὰ πασῶν τῶν τεχνῶν οὕτω σοι δοκεῖ, τῇ μὲν αὐτῇ τέχνῃ τὰ αὐτὰ ἀναγκαῖον εἶναι γινώσκειν, τῇ δ' ἐτέρᾳ μὴ τὰ αὐτά, ἀλλ' εἴπερ ἄλλη ἐστίν, ἀναγκαῖον καὶ ἕτερα γινώσκειν. ΙΩΝ. οὕτω μοι δοκεῖ, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν ὅστις ἂν μὴ ἔχη τινὰ τέχνην, ταύτης τῆς τέχνης τὰ λεγόμενα ἢ πραττόμενα καλῶς γινώσκειν οὐχ οἷός τ' ἔσται; ΙΩΝ.

IO: Yes, Socrates, that's what I think.

S: Won't someone who does not possess a particular skill be unable properly to understand whatever accounts or activities are associated with that skill?

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IO: That's true.

ἀληθῆ λέγεις. ΣΩ. πότερον οὖν περὶ τῶν ἐπῶν ὧν εἶπες, εἴτε καλῶς λέγει Ὅμηρος εἴτε μή, σὺ κάλλιον γνώσῃ ἢ ἡνίοχος; ΙΩΝ. Ἡνίοχος. ΣΩ. Ῥαψῳδὸς γάρ που εἶ ἀλλ' οὐχ ἡνίοχος. ΙΩΝ. ναί. ΣΩ. ἢ δὲ ῥαψῳδικὴ τέχνη ἑτέρα ἐστὶ τῆς ἡνιοχικῆς; ΙΩΝ. ναί. ΣΩ. εἰ ἄρα ἑτέρα, περὶ ἐτέρων καὶ ἐπιστήμη πραγμάτων ἐστίν. ΙΩΝ. ναί. ΣΩ. τί δὲ δὴ ὅταν Ὅμηρος λέγῃ ὥς τετρωμένῳ τῷ Μαχάονι Ἑκαμήδη ἢ Νέστορος παλλακὴ κυκεῶνα πίνειν

S: Now, in relation to the lines you recited, would you or a charioteer better understand whether or not Homer is speaking correctly?

IO: A charioteer.

S: Presumably because you are a rhapsode, but not a charioteer?

IO: Yes.

S: And the skill of a rhapsode is different from that of a charioteer?

IO: Yes.

S: So, if it is different, it is also a knowledge of different things.

IO: Yes.

538c

S: What about the passage where Homer recounts how Hecamede, Nestor's concubine, gives the wounded Machaon a posset to drink? He says something like this: "With Pramnian wine, she grated goat's-milk cheese into it with a bronze / grater, with onion on the side as an appetizer for the drink." Does it belong to the skill of the physician or the skill of the rhapsode to fully understand aright whether or not Homer is speaking correctly in these lines.

δίδωσι; καὶ λέγει πως οὕτως— οἴνω πραμνείω, φησίν, ἐπὶ δ' αἴγειον
κνή τυρὸν κνήσῃ χαλκείῃ· παρὰ δὲ κρόμμον ποτῶ ὄψον· ταῦτα εἴτε
ὀρθῶς λέγει Ὅμηρος εἴτε μή, πότερον ἱατρικῆς ἐστὶ διαγνῶναι καλῶς ἢ
ῥαψωδικῆς; **ΙΩΝ.** Ἱατρικῆς. **ΣΩ.** τί δέ, ὅταν λέγῃ Ὅμηρος—

IO: The skill of the physician.

538d

S: What about when Homer says: “She plummeted to the sea floor like a
lead weight which, mounted / along the horn of an ox who ranges the
fields, goes downward / and takes death with it to the raw-ravaging
fish.” Should we say that it belongs to the art of the angler rather than
of the rhapsode to decide what he is saying and whether he is speaking
correctly or incorrectly?

ἡ δὲ μολυβδαίνῃ ἱκέλη ἐς βυσσὸν ἵκανεν, ἢ τε κατ' ἀγραύλοιο βοὸς
κέρας ἐμμεμαυῖα ἔρχεται ὠμηστῆσι μετ' ἰχθύσι πῆμα φέρουσα· ταῦτα
πότερον φῶμεν ἀλιευτικῆς εἶναι τέχνης μᾶλλον κρῖναι ἢ ῥαψωδικῆς,
ἅττα λέγει καὶ εἴτε καλῶς εἴτε μή; **ΙΩΝ.** Δῆλον δὴ, ὦ Σώκρατες, ὅτι
ἀλιευτικῆς. **ΣΩ.** σκέψαι δὴ, σοῦ ἐρομένου, εἰ ἔροιο με· ἐπειδὴ

IO: The angler of course, Socrates.

538e

S: Then, consider this. Suppose you, as the questioner, were to ask me,
“Well, Socrates, since you are finding in Homer what is appropriate for
each of these skills to decide upon, please find out for me also, in the
case of the prophet and prophecy, what sort of things are for the
prophet to decide upon and appreciate whether Homer has composed
well or ill.” Observe how easily and truly I shall reply to you. Indeed,
there are numerous instances. For example, in the *Odyssey*, he recounts
that the prophet Theoclymenos, a descendant of Melampus, says to the
suitors: “Fortunate fellows, what evil has come upon you? Your heads
and faces and / limbs are shrouded in night and darkness; a sound of
wailing has broken out, / your cheeks are covered with tears. All the
forecourt is huddled with ghosts, / the yard is full of them as they flock
down to the underworld and the darkness. / The sun has perished out

of the sky, and a foul mist has come over.” And there are many examples in the Iliad too – for example, in the Battle at the Wall, where he says: “As they were urgent to cross a bird sign had appeared to them, / an eagle, flying high and holding to the left of the people / and carrying in its talons a gigantic snake, blood-coloured, / alive still and breathing, it had not forgotten its warcraft / yet, for writhing back it struck the eagle that held it / by chest and neck, so that the eagle let it drop groundward / in pain of the bite and dashed it down in the midst of the battle / and itself, screaming high, winged away down the wind’s blast.” I shall maintain that it belongs to the prophet to consider and judge these passages and their like.

τοίνυν, ὦ Σώκρατες, τούτων τῶν τεχνῶν ἐν Ὀμήρῳ εὐρίσκεῖς ἃ προσήκει ἐκάστη διακρίνειν, ἴθι μοι ἔξευρε καὶ τὰ τοῦ μάντεώς τε καὶ μαντικῆς, ποῖά ἐστιν ἃ προσήκει αὐτῷ οἶω τ’ εἶναι διαγιγνώσκειν, εἴτε εὖ εἴτε κακῶς πεποιήται — σκέψαι ὡς ῥαδίως τε καὶ ἀληθῆ ἐγὼ σοι ἀποκρινοῦμαι. πολλαχοῦ μὲν γὰρ καὶ ἐν Ὀδυσσεΐᾳ λέγει, οἶον καὶ ἃ ὁ τῶν Μελαμποδιδῶν λέγει μάντις πρὸς τοὺς μνηστήρας, Θεοκλύμενος—
ΣΩ. δαιμόνιοι, τί κακὸν τόδε πάσχετε; νυκτὶ μὲν ὑμέων εἰλύαται κεφαλαί τε πρόσωπά τε νέρθε τε γυῖα, οἰμωγὴ δὲ δέδηκε, δεδάκρυνται δὲ παρειαί· εἰδῶλων τε πλεον πρόθυρον, πλείη δὲ καὶ αὐλὴ ἱεμένων ἔρεβόςδε ὑπὸ ζόφον· ἥελιος δὲ οὐρανοῦ ἐξαπόλωλε, κακὴ δ’ ἐπιδέδρομεν ἀχλύς· πολλαχοῦ δὲ καὶ ἐν Ἰλιάδι, οἶον καὶ ἐπὶ τειχομαχίᾳ· λέγει γὰρ καὶ ἐνταῦθα -- ὄρνις γὰρ σφιν ἐπῆλθε περησέμεναι μεμαῶσιν, αἰετὸς ὑψιπέτης, ἐπ’ ἀριστερὰ λαὸν ἐέργων,

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Io: What you say is true, Socrates.

φοινήεντα δράκοντα φέρων ὀνύχεσσι πέλωρον, ζῶον, ἔτ’ ἀσπαίροντα· καὶ οὐπω λήθετο χάρμης. κόψε γὰρ αὐτὸν ἔχοντα κατὰ στήθος παρὰ δεξιὴν ἰδνωθεὶς ὀπίσω, ὁ δ’ ἀπὸ ἔθεν ἦκε χαμαῖζε ἀλγήσας ὀδύνῃσι, μέσφ’ ἐνὶ κάββαλ’ ὀμίλῃ·

539d

S: And what you are saying is also true, Ion. Come on then, and do for me what I did for you. I selected, from the *Odyssey* and *Iliad*, passages that treat of the prophet and of the physician and of the angler. Now, since you have more experience of Homer than I have, Ion, you should select passages that treat of the rhapsode and the rhapsode's skill, passages that the rhapsode, more so than anyone else, should consider and judge.

αὐτὸς δὲ κλάγξας πέτετο πνοιῆς ἀνέμοιο. ταῦτα φήσω καὶ τὰ τοιαῦτα τῷ μάντει προσήκειν καὶ σκοπεῖν καὶ κρίνειν. **ΙΩΝ.** ἀληθῆ γε σὺ λέγων, ὦ Σώκρατες. **ΣΩ.** καὶ σύ γε, ὦ Ἴων, ἀληθῆ ταῦτα λέγεις. ἴθι δὴ καὶ σὺ ἐμοί, ὥσπερ ἐγὼ σοὶ ἐξέλεξα καὶ ἐξ Ὀδυσσεΐας καὶ ἐξ Ἰλιάδος ὅποια τοῦ μάντεώς ἐστι καὶ ὅποια τοῦ ἱατροῦ καὶ

ΙΟ: All of them, Socrates. That's my answer.

539e

S: All of them, Ion? That's not your answer, or are you so forgetful? And yet it would be quite inappropriate for a rhapsode to be forgetful.

ὅποια τοῦ ἀλιέως, οὕτω καὶ σὺ ἐμοὶ ἔκλεξον, ἐπειδὴ καὶ ἐμπειρότερος εἶ ἐμοῦ τῶν Ὀμήρου, ὅποια τοῦ ῥαψωδοῦ ἐστίν, ὦ Ἴων, καὶ τῆς τέχνης τῆς ῥαψωδικῆς, ἃ τῷ ῥαψωδῷ προσήκει καὶ σκοπεῖσθαι καὶ διακρίνειν παρὰ τοὺς ἄλλους ἀνθρώπους. **ΙΩΝ.** ἐγὼ μὲν φημι, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἅπαντα. **ΣΩ.** οὐ σύ γε φῆς, ὦ Ἴων, ἅπαντα ἢ οὕτως ἐπιλήσμων εἶ; καίτοι οὐκ ἂν πρέποι γε ἐπιλήσμονα εἶναι ῥαψωδὸν ἄνδρα.

ΙΟ: What am I forgetting?

S: Don't you remember agreeing that the rhapsode's skill is different from that of the charioteer?

ΙΟ: I remember.

S: Don't you agree that, being different, it would understand different things?

ΙΟ: Yes.

S: So, according to your argument, neither the rhapsode nor the rhapsode's skill will know everything.

540a

IO: Perhaps, Socrates, with the exception of such matters as these.

ΙΩΝ. τί δὲ δὴ ἐπιλανθάνομαι; ΣΩ. οὐ μέμνησαι ὅτι ἔφησθα τὴν ῥαψωδικὴν τέχνην ἑτέραν εἶναι τῆς ἡνιοχικῆς; ΙΩΝ. μέμνημαι. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν καὶ ἑτέραν οὖσαν ἕτερα γνώσεσθαι ὠμολόγεις; ΙΩΝ. ναί. ΣΩ. οὐκ ἄρα πάντα γε γινώσεται ἡ ῥαψωδικὴ κατὰ τὸν σὸν λόγον οὐδὲ ὁ ῥαψωδός. ΙΩΝ. πλὴν γε ἴσως τὰ τοιαῦτα, ὦ Σώκρατες.

S: By “such matters as these” do you mean more or less anything that belongs to the other skills? But since it does not know everything, what sort of things will it know?

IO: The sort of thing that is appropriate for a man to say, I suppose, or for a woman either, or for a slave or free man, or for a subject or someone in charge.

540b

S: So, are you saying that a rhapsode will know better than a steersman the sorts of things that are appropriate for a person in charge of a ship to say when at sea in a storm?

ΣΩ. τὰ τοιαῦτα δὲ λέγεις πλὴν τὰ τῶν ἄλλων τεχνῶν σχεδόν τι· ἀλλὰ ποῖα δὲ γινώσεται, ἐπειδὴ οὐχ ἅπαντα; ΙΩΝ. ἂν πρέπει, οἶμαι ἔγωγε, ἀνδρὶ εἰπεῖν καὶ ὅποια γυναικί, καὶ ὅποια δούλῳ καὶ ὅποια ἐλευθέρῳ, καὶ ὅποια ἀρχομένῳ καὶ ὅποια ἄρχοντι. ΣΩ. ἄρα ὅποια ἄρχοντι, λέγεις, ἐν θαλάττῃ χειμαζομένου πλοίου πρέπει εἰπεῖν, ὁ ῥαψωδός γινώσεται κάλλιον ἢ ὁ κυβερνήτης; ΙΩΝ. οὐκ, ἀλλὰ ὁ κυβερνήτης τοῦτό γε.

IO: No, a steersman knows this.

S: But will the rhapsode know better than the physician what sort of thing is appropriate for someone in charge of the sick to say?

IO: He won't know this either.

S: But you say that he knows the sort of thing that is appropriate for a slave to say?

IO: Yes.

540c

S: Are you saying, for instance, that a rhapsode, rather than a cowherd, will know what sort of things are appropriate for a slave who is a cowherd to say to soothe the cattle when they are wild?

ΣΩ. ἀλλ' ὅποια ἄρχοντι κάμνοντος πρέπει εἰπεῖν, ὁ ῥαψωδὸς γινώσεται κάλλιον ἢ ὁ ἱατρός; ΙΩΝ. οὐδὲ τοῦτο. ΣΩ. ἀλλ' οἷα δούλῳ πρέπει, λέγεις; ΙΩΝ. ναί. ΣΩ. οἷον βουκόλῳ λέγεις δούλῳ ἃ πρέπει εἰπεῖν ἀγριαίνουσιν βοῶν παραμυθουμένων, ὁ ῥαψωδὸς γινώσεται ἀλλ' οὐχ ὁ βουκόλος; ΙΩΝ. οὐ δῆτα. ΣΩ. ἀλλ' οἷα γυναικὶ πρόποντά ἐστιν εἰπεῖν ταλασιουργῶ περὶ ἐρίων

IO: Of course not.

S: Will he know the sort of things that are appropriate for a woman who spins wool to say about the working of wool?

IO: No.

540d

S: Will he know then the sort of things that are appropriate for a man who is a general to say to his soldiers when exhorting them?

ἐργασίας; ΙΩΝ. οὐ. ΣΩ. ἀλλ' οἷα ἀνδρὶ πρέπει εἰπεῖν γινώσεται στρατηγῶ στρατιώταις παραινοῦντι; ΙΩΝ. ναί, τὰ τοιαῦτα γινώσεται ὁ ῥαψωδός. ΣΩ. τί δέ; ἡ ῥαψωδικὴ τέχνη στρατηγικὴ ἐστίν; ΙΩΝ. Γνοίην γοῦν ἂν ἔγωγε οἷα στρατηγὸν πρέπει εἰπεῖν. ΣΩ. ἴσως γὰρ εἴ καὶ στρατηγικός, ὧ Ἴων. καὶ γὰρ εἰ ἐτύγχανες ἵππικὸς ὦν ἅμα καὶ κιθαριστικός, ἔγνωσ ἂν ἵππους

IO: Yes, the rhapsode will know that sort of thing.

S: But why? Is the skill of the rhapsode the skill of the general?

IO: Well, I myself would at least know the sorts of things that are appropriate for the general to say.

540e

S: For you are, perhaps, also skilled as a general, Ion. And indeed, if you happened to be skilled simultaneously in both horsemanship and lyre-playing, you would understand when horses are being handled well or handled badly. But what if I were to ask you, Ion, by what skill you understand that horses are being well handled? Is it by the skill of the horseman or the skill of the lyre player? How would you answer me?

εὖ καὶ κακῶς ἵππαζομένους· ἀλλ' εἴ σ' ἐγὼ ἡρόμην· ποτέρᾳ δὴ τέχνῃ, ὦ Ἴων, γινώσκεις τοὺς εὖ ἵππαζομένους ἵππους; ἢ ἵππεὺς εἶ ἢ ἢ καθαριστής; τί ἄν μοι ἀπεκρίνω; **ΙΩΝ.** ἢ ἵππεύς, ἔγωγ' ἄν. **ΣΩ.** οὐκοῦν εἰ καὶ τοὺς εὖ καθαρίζοντας διεγίνωσκεις, ὡμολόγεις ἄν, ἢ καθαριστὴς εἶ, ταύτῃ διαγινώσκεις, ἀλλ' οὐχ ἢ ἵππεύς. **ΙΩΝ.** ναί. **ΣΩ.** ἐπειδὴ δὲ τὰ στρατιωτικὰ γινώσκεις, πότερον ἢ στρατηγικὸς εἶ γινώσκεις ἢ ἢ ῥαψωδὸς ἀγαθός; **ΙΩΝ.** οὐδὲν ἔμοιγε δοκεῖ διαφέρειν.

ΙΟ: By the skill of the horseman. That would be my reply.

S: Now, if you also recognised those who play the lyre well, you would accept that you do so by means of your skill as a lyre player, not by your skill as a horseman,

ΙΟ: Yes.

S: When you understand military matters, are you doing so by means of your skill as a general or as a good rhapsode?

ΙΟ: I don't think there is any difference.

541a

S: How so? You say there is no difference. Are you saying that the rhapsode's skill and the general's skill are one, or are they two?

ΣΩ. πῶς; οὐδὲν λέγεις διαφέρειν; μίαν λέγεις τέχνην εἶναι τὴν ῥαψωδικὴν καὶ τὴν στρατηγικὴν ἢ δύο; **ΙΩΝ.** μία ἔμοιγε δοκεῖ. **ΣΩ.** ὅστις ἄρα ἀγαθὸς ῥαψωδὸς ἐστίν, οὗτος καὶ ἀγαθὸς στρατηγὸς τυγχάνει ὦν; **ΙΩΝ.** μάλιστα, ὦ Σώκρατες. **ΣΩ.** οὐκοῦν καὶ ὅστις ἀγαθὸς στρατηγὸς τυγχάνει ὦν, ἀγαθὸς καὶ ῥαψωδὸς ἐστίν. **ΙΩΝ.** οὐκ αὖ μοι δοκεῖ τοῦτο. **ΣΩ.** ἀλλ' ἐκεῖνο μὴν δοκεῖ σοι, ὅστις γε ἀγαθός

IO: In my opinion, they are one.

S: So, anyone who is a good rhapsode turns out to be a good general too?

IO: Very much so, Socrates.

S: Therefore, anyone who happens to be a good general is also a good rhapsode.

IO: No, I don't agree with that.

541b

S: But you do agree that anyone who is a good rhapsode is also a good general?

ῥαψωδός, καὶ στρατηγὸς ἀγαθὸς εἶναι; ΙΩΝ. πάνυ γε. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν σὺ τῶν Ἑλλήνων ἄριστος ῥαψωδὸς εἶ; ΙΩΝ. πολὺ γε, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. ἦ καὶ στρατηγός, ὦ Ἴων, τῶν Ἑλλήνων ἄριστος εἶ; ΙΩΝ. εὖ ἴσθι, ὦ Σώκρατες· καὶ ταῦτά γε ἐκ τῶν Ὀμήρου μαθὼν. ΣΩ. τί δὴ ποτ' οὖν πρὸς τῶν θεῶν, ὦ Ἴων, ἀμφοτέρω ἄριστος ὢν τῶν Ἑλλήνων, καὶ στρατηγὸς καὶ ῥαψωδός, ῥαψωδεῖς μὲν περιῶν τοῖς Ἑλλησι, στρατηγεῖς δ' οὐ; ἦ

IO: Certainly.

S: Aren't you the best rhapsode of all the Greeks?

IO: By far, Socrates.

S: And also the best general of all, Ion?

IO: Of that you may be sure, Socrates, and I have learned this from Homer.

541c

S: Why then, by the gods, Ion, do you go around Greece as a rhapsode and not as a general, when you are both the best rhapsode of all the Greeks and the best general too? Or do you think that the Greeks have a great need for a rhapsode crowned with a wreath of gold, but no need for a general?

ράψωδοῦ μὲν δοκεῖ σοι χρυσῶ στεφάνῳ ἔστεφανωμένου πολλή χρεῖα εἶναι τοῖς Ἑλλήσι, στρατηγοῦ δὲ οὐδεμία; ΙΩΝ. ἡ μὲν γὰρ ἡμετέρα, ὦ Σώκρατες, πόλις ἄρχεται ὑπὸ ὑμῶν καὶ στρατηγεῖται καὶ οὐδὲν δεῖται στρατηγοῦ, ἡ δὲ ὑμετέρα καὶ ἡ Λακεδαιμονίων οὐκ ἂν με ἔλοιτο στρατηγόν· αὐτοὶ γὰρ οἴεσθε ἱκανοὶ εἶναι. ΣΩ. ὦ βέλτιστε Ἴων, Ἀπολλόδωρον οὐ γιγνώσκεις τὸν Κυζικηνόν; ΙΩΝ. ποῖον τοῦτον; ΣΩ. ὃν Ἀθηναῖοι πολλὰκις ἑαυτῶν στρατηγὸν ἤρηνται

IO: Well, Socrates, our city is under the rulership and military command of your city and has no need for a general, and neither your people nor the Spartans would choose me as a general because they think that they have enough themselves.

S: Ion, my good man, you do know Apollodorus of Cyzicus?

IO: Who is he?

541d

S: A man whom the Athenians have often chosen for themselves as a general, even though he is a foreigner. And this city appoints Phanosthenes of Andros and Herakleides of Clazomenae to military command and other positions of authority, proving that they are noteworthy even though they are foreigners. So why would Ion of Ephesus not be chosen as a general, and respected, if he too seems worthy of note? You Ephesians were originally Athenians, were you not, and Ephesus is a city second to none? But in fact, Ion, if your claim to be able to praise Homer with knowledge and expertise is actually true, you are doing me an injustice. You promise me that you have knowledge of the manifold beauties of Homer, and you say that you will demonstrate them. But you deceive me and you fall far short of demonstrating them, and you are not even prepared to explain on what matters you are an expert, even though I have been imploring you for some time. You are much like Proteus¹¹, assuming all sorts of forms, turning this way and that, until finally you escape me by appearing in the guise of a general to avoid demonstrating your expertise in the wisdom of Homer. Now, if you have expertise in Homer,

then, as I said just now, by promising to give me a demonstration you have deceived me, and you are acting unjustly. However, there is no injustice if you have no expertise but are describing the manifold beauties of the poet possessed, as I said, by a divine portion from Homer, while knowing nothing. So, decide whether you want us to regard you as an unjust man or as divine.

ξένον ὄντα καὶ Φανοσθένη τὸν Ἄνδριον καὶ Ἡρακλείδην τὸν Κλαζομένιον, οὓς ἤδε ἡ πόλις ξένους ὄντας, ἐνδειξαμένους ὅτι ἄξιοι λόγου εἰσί, καὶ εἰς στρατηγίας καὶ εἰς τὰς ἄλλας ἀρχὰς ἄγει· Ἴωνα δ' ἄρα τὸν Ἐφέσιον οὐχ αἰρήσεται στρατηγὸν καὶ τιμήσει, ἐὰν δοκῇ ἄξιος λόγου εἶναι; τί δέ; οὐκ Ἀθηναῖοι μὲν ἔστε οἱ Ἐφέσιοι τὸ ἀρχαῖον, καὶ ἡ Ἐφεσος οὐδεμιᾶς ἐλάττων πόλεως; ἀλλὰ γὰρ σύ, ὦ Ἴων, εἰ μὲν ἀληθῆ λέγεις ὡς τέχνη καὶ ἐπιστήμη οἷός τε εἶ Ὅμηρον ἐπαινεῖν, ἀδικεῖς, ὅστις ἐμοὶ ὑποσχόμενος ὡς πολλὰ καὶ καλὰ περὶ Ὀμήρου ἐπίστασαι καὶ φάσκων ἐπιδείξιν, ἐξαπατᾷς με καὶ πολλοῦ δεῖς ἐπιδεῖξαι, ὅς γε οὐδὲ ἅττα ἐστὶ ταῦτα περὶ ὧν δεινὸς εἶ ἐθέλεις εἰπεῖν, πάλαι ἐμοῦ λιπαροῦντος, ΣΩ. ἀλλ' ἀτεχνῶς ὥσπερ ὁ Πρωτεύς παντοδαπὸς γίγνηι στρεφόμενος ἄνω καὶ κάτω, ἕως τελευτῶν διαφυγὼν με στρατηγὸς ἀνεφάνης,

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IO: There is a big difference Socrates. Indeed, the divine is regarded as better by far.

ἵνα μὴ ἐπιδείξῃς ὡς δεινὸς εἶ τὴν περὶ Ὀμήρου σοφίαν. εἰ μὲν οὖν τεχνικὸς ὢν, ὅπερ νυνδὴ ἔλεγον, περὶ Ὀμήρου ὑποσχόμενος ἐπιδείξῃς ἐξαπατᾷς με, ἄδικος εἶ· εἰ δὲ μὴ τεχνικὸς εἶ, ἀλλὰ θεῖα μοῖρα κατεχόμενος ἐξ Ὀμήρου μηδὲν εἰδὼς πολλὰ καὶ καλὰ λέγεις περὶ τοῦ ποιητοῦ, ὥσπερ ἐγὼ εἶπον περὶ σοῦ, οὐδὲν ἀδικεῖς. ἐλοῦ οὖν πότερα βούλει νομίζεσθαι ὑπὸ ἡμῶν ἄδικος ἀνὴρ εἶναι ἢ θεῖος.

542b

S: In that case, Ion, we grant you this better portion – to be divine and not to praise Homer based on some expertise.

ΙΩΝ. πολὺν διαφέρει, ὦ Σώκρατες· πολὺ γὰρ κάλλιον τὸ θεῖον νομίζεσθαι. ΣΩ. τοῦτο τοίνυν τὸ κάλλιον ὑπάρχει σοι παρ' ἡμῖν, ὦ Ἴων, θεῖον εἶναι καὶ μὴ τεχνικὸν περὶ Ὀμήρου ἐπαινέτην.

Notes

¹ Ion was a rhapsode from Ephesus in Asia Minor, which at the time was a colony of Athens. He specialised in the works of Homer.

² Metrodorus of Lampsacus, Stesimbrotos of Thasos, and Glaucón of Rhegium were all prominent interpreters of Homer.

³ The Homerids were a guild of rhapsodes.

⁴ This reflects the idea that natural magnets were thought to come from the region that included Magnesia and Heraclea, from which they derived their names.

⁵ Those who worshipped Bacchus would dance themselves into a frenzy in which they would find rivers flowing with milk and honey.

⁶ Iliad xxiii.335-340, Lattimore (adjusted to conform to Plato's text).

⁷ Iliad xi.639-640, Lattimore.

⁸ Iliad xxiv.80-82, Lattimore.

⁹ Odyssey xx.351-357, Lattimore.

¹⁰ Iliad xii.200-207, Lattimore.

¹¹ Proteus was an early sea god. He was associated with the changeability of the seas and other bodies of water, and was thus depicted as being able to take any shape he wanted. Odyssey iv.385 ff.